

Ghiglia: "A Tax on Big Tech for the Digital Education of All"

The lawsuit in New York against Big Tech and Sam Altman's concerns about AI highlight the risks of dependence on social media and the need to regulate AI. An education tax to fund digital education and the establishment of a UN for AI could ensure ethical use of technology and protect us from its risks.

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Two news items, in my opinion, have recently shaken the universe surrounding Artificial Intelligence and/or social media, complementary faces of the multifaceted universe of AI itself: the lawsuit filed by the City of New York against social media and the latest statements from the Patron of ChatGPT, Sam Altman.

****The lawsuit filed by New York against social media****

The lawsuit brought by the Big Apple against Big Tech (TikTok, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, and Snapchat) highlights a broader issue afflicting contemporary society, certainly related to the growing dependence—not only of younger generations—on social media, but also to the massive, indiscriminate, and presumably not always compliant collection of personal data by the platforms, as well as the increasing concerns regarding the use and regulation of artificial intelligence (AI).

****The effects of social media use on mental health****

According to the drafters of the lawsuit, social media "would fuel psychological crises among young people never seen before," while the algorithms they use "attract, trap, and feed addiction." Without delving into the increasingly serious and current issue of "Hikikomori," let anyone who, after watching a reel, has not "scrolled" for at least 15 minutes raise their hand (note that, shortly, with Neuralink, we will be able to know if you are telling the truth).

****Sam Altman's concerns about unregulated AI****

Sam Altman, a prominent figure in the field of AI, expressed serious concerns about the potential threats that unregulated AI could pose to society, emphasizing how the absence of an adequate regulatory framework makes him, euphemistically, uneasy: "I can't sleep at night if I think about the risks and the lack of rules." Our speaker is no stranger to such statements: "If this technology goes wrong, it can go very wrong..." (5/2023). "...It must be kept in check, limited by law, and controlled by an International Agency... just as has been done for nuclear weapons." "We must be careful; we are also a bit scared" (3/2023). Now, if Sam Altman cannot sleep, we and our digital twins should be doubly concerned: about the consequences on the training of algorithms derived from fragmented insomnia and, more seriously, about the evident risks associated with the unregulated use of a tool, without using other adjectives, extremely powerful for and about our lives.

****The impact of AI on the cognitive and social development of younger generations****

Altman's statements highlight a crucial aspect of the current debate: AI, and particularly generative artificial intelligence, has the potential to either positively and virtuously revolutionize our world or present significant risks, especially for the intellectual and cultural development of younger generations, regardless of the employment implications that are not our concern here. AI can influence how we learn, think, and interact with one another, potentially limiting our capacity for critical thinking and creativity if we become overly dependent on it for information processing and problem-solving. This concern extends beyond the boundaries of education and touches on fundamental issues of autonomy and personal identity, reaching into free will and the ability to discern between what is right and what is wrong.

If younger generations grow up in an environment where AI provides ready answers and easy solutions, results without effort or consultation of multiple sources, they may lose the ability to tackle complex challenges, develop critical thinking, and evaluate information in a conscious, thoughtful, and independent manner. Such a scenario would not only impoverish the intellectual and cultural fabric of society but would also undermine, in the long run, the foundations of democracy and civic participation, which are based on the ability of citizens to think freely and autonomously and to act based on that

thought.

****The importance of regulation and education in the era of AI****

A balanced approach to AI regulation, encompassing both legislative measures and educational initiatives, is essential to mitigate the risks highlighted by Altman and other experts. Legal actions like the one in New York, with all the uncertainties of risk and the certainly lengthy timelines for their resolution, can play a crucial role in crystallizing and demonstrating the potential liabilities of the companies involved (and the other hundreds not called into question...) but represent only a part of the solution as they address the problem downstream and not upstream. A holistic strategy, on the other hand, that includes regulation and the active involvement of all stakeholders—governments, companies, educational communities, and the public—is, in my opinion, the best and most useful way to navigate safely and responsibly in the era of artificial intelligence.

It is also essential that the dialogue on these issues remains open and inclusive, moves out of the classrooms and down from the lecterns, involving not only experts and legislators but also public opinion and associations (with particular regard to those dealing with minors and the elderly). Only through collective commitment can we ensure that the potential benefits of AI are accessible to all and that its risks are limited and not harmful to individuals and their Rights.

A “digital education tax” as a possible solution for the regulation of AI

In this context, education plays a key role, and the digital education tax – a tax aimed at digital education that Big Tech should pay to each State in proportion to the number of users present in that State – could be the most effective tool for its dissemination, allowing, thanks to substantial resources, to prepare younger generations to live humanely in an increasingly digital and automated world, but also to ensure that society as a whole can address the ethical, social, and cultural issues raised by AI.

Well-designed educational programs can help bridge the gap between the ultra-rapid technological evolution and our ability to understand and govern its impacts.

The possible uses of the digital education tax

The proposal for a digital education tax, in this context, acquires a new dimension: it could not only finance, as mentioned above, campaigns for digital civic education, but it could also support programs specifically designed to teach students how to use AI critically and consciously. These programs could include lessons on how algorithms work, how they can be “biased” (or “distorted” for Boomers and Generation X), and how users can maintain control over their data and the automated decisions made on their behalf.

Moreover, the digital education tax could fund research on how AI could be used ethically in education and professional development, as well as structuring initiatives that promote diversity and inclusion in the field of technology. Such resources could also serve to address the digital divide and ensure that everyone has access to the opportunities offered by AI, preventing and mitigating the possible exacerbation of existing inequalities.

In addition to the aforementioned points, the digital education tax could help finance initiatives aimed at promoting transparency and accountability in the use of AI by companies, including the implementation of independent audits and the publication of reports on the social impact of their technologies. Such activities could help build greater public trust in AI applications and ensure that their development is based on and guided by solid ethical settings and not just commercial objectives.

Another area where the digital education tax could make a difference is in supporting research on responsible and inclusive AI methods through the development of unbiased algorithms that ensure AI systems are accessible to people of all ages, abilities, and socio-economic backgrounds, as well as promoting a digital environment that respects and values human diversity.

An UN dedicated to Artificial Intelligence

Finally, it is essential that the policies supported by the digital education tax reflect a global vision, taking into account the diverse cultural, social, and economic realities. In an interconnected world, the

risks and opportunities of AI transcend national borders, making international cooperation essential. Education and regulation strategies should therefore be developed in a global dialogue, ensuring that all countries have a say and that the solutions adopted are equitably distributed and accessible.

In this regard, it would be necessary to expand upon Sam Altman's suggestion, namely to create a UN dedicated to Artificial Intelligence where, with patents laid down, supercomputers silenced, and commercial interests and intercontinental competition set aside (not eliminated), the minimum foundations for regulation aimed at the good of the human person would be established, which, beyond good intentions and commendable results, would not only engage that one-fifth of the world population corresponding to Old Europe.

Conclusions

In conclusion, while the legal action taken by New York against social platforms highlights immediate and tangible issues, the question of AI requires broader but much more urgent reflection given the hypersonic speed of technological development. The digital education tax represents an innovative proposal that could provide the necessary resources to systematically address these issues, promoting a safe, ethical, and beneficial use of AI for society as a whole. By addressing today's problems and anticipating those of tomorrow, we can work together to ensure that the digital revolution brings benefits to all, without compromising the fundamental values of autonomy, personal data protection, and social justice.

As for the UN of AI, who knows... After all, even in the Digital Age, dreaming costs nothing but, above all, it allows for peaceful sleep.